



On a roll: South Africa's series win, its first in India in 25 years, is the strongest stamp of validation it has received since its coronation as World Test Champion earlier this year. RITU RAJ KONWAR

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The point of denial is over. India's 2-0 Test series defeat to South Africa at home all but confirms that its capitulation to New Zealand last year was not an aberration.

This was a stark assertion of the flaws that run through the current Indian Test team, marking an end to a long-standing era of home dominance.

If we were to be generous, we could partly attribute India's defeat in Kolkata to the unfortunate injury Shubman Gill suffered early in the Test. South Africa's 30-run margin could have been overturned if the Indian skipper had batted through.

India's surrender in the second Test, though, was as abject as it comes. Except for the opening day, when the game hung in the balance, India was outplayed on every single day, on every single front.

At the post-match press conference in Guwahati, Indian coach Gautam Gambhir cited his squad's lack of experience as a defence for its performance against the Proteas.

The transition excuse, though, is a disservice to the quality of players at Gambhir's disposal. In Jasprit Bumrah, Ravindra Jadeja and Rishabh Pant, he has three experienced Test players. Add to that Kuldeep Yadav, who is arguably the

best left-arm wrist-spinner in Test history.

Lesser teams, with fewer generational players, have managed to present a more credible face in Test cricket, at least at home.

Central to India's downfall was its brittle batting line-up — across four innings against the Proteas, the side crossed 200 just once.

The Indian batters exhibited a particular sense of dread while facing off-spinner Simon Harmer (**below**). The 36-year-old bagged 17 wickets in the series at an incredible average of 8.94.

It was not just spin that troubled them. In Guwahati, India's short-ball frailties were exposed by Marco Jansen, who delivered a devastating spell of pace bowling in the first innings, determining the fate of the Test.

The home team also went out of its way to

